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State Won't Get That Gas Hike After All

SACRAMENTO (AP) — California is not going to get the extra 46.5-million-gallon gasoline allocation this month that state officials had expected, a federal energy spokesman said yesterday.

The increase had been reported Wednesday after state and federal energy officials in California received a telegram from the Federal Energy Office spelling out the state's March allocation.

State energy chief Wesley Bruer told reporters Wednesday that he interpreted the telegram to say California would pick up the additional 46.5 million gallons above the state's original 778.7-million-gallon March allocation.

But Alan Hoffard, a spokesman for the FEO regional office in San Francisco, said state officials consulted with the Washington FEO office yesterday and found the interpretation was wrong.

"It was our misinterpretation on this coast of their telegram," said Hoffard.

"Some ambiguous language in the telegram implied that there would be a 6.3 per cent improvement in our California allocation for motor gasoline for March."

Both the regional office and state energy officials thought the telegram indicated a 46.5 million gallon hike in the March allocation.

Bruer was not available for comment, but Harold Berthoff, Bruer's assistant, said, "We misinterpreted it, but it looks to us like 778.7-million-gallons now. We don't have any official word yet."

But, Berthoff added, the 778.7-million figure, which equals 85 per cent of March, 1972, gasoline sales in California, is about six per cent more than earlier estimates of California fuel allocations.

Hoffard said the 6.3 per cent figure mentioned in the telegram actually related to the way oil companies were directed to handle their March allocation in California and had nothing to do with an increased allocation.

Hoffard said California's gasoline allocation picture was not completely bleak, however, because if the Arab oil embargo is definitely lifted "we hope to have an increase in California's allocation later this month."

But Hoffard said he didn't expect to have any idea on how much that increase might be until sometime next week.

Gas Stations to Open on Sunday

SACRAMENTO (AP)—At least 823 additional service stations will be open Sundays in California in response to a plea from Gov. Ronald Reagan, the governor's office said yesterday.

Reagan sent telegrams to major oil companies asking them voluntarily to open their company-owned and operated stations on Sundays, said assistant press secretary Rudy Garcia.

Garcia said Standard Oil of California, the state's biggest single owner of service stations, had not replied by yesterday evening. But he said four other companies had agreed.

He said the replies indicate there will be an extra 508 Union stations, 200 Douglas stations, 66 Gulf stations and 51 Mobil stations beginning this weekend.

500 Unsafe Mines May Be Closed

WASHINGTON (AP) — Despite appeals from the Federal Energy Office, the Interior Department said yesterday it will order the closing of 500 coal mines March 30 for failing to comply with government safety laws.

The mines, mostly small independent operations, account for about 5 per cent of U.S. coal production or about 30 million tons a year.

Interior Secretary Rogers C. B. Morton upheld the findings of James M. Day, chief of the Mine Safety and Enforcement Administration, that there was no legal way to amend the 1969 federal Coal Mine Health and Safety Act to permit continued operation of the mines.

Sources said Morton feared that if the rules were changed and there was a future disaster "he (Morton) would be the guy to catch hell."

Under the 1969 law, small mines were given until March 30, 1974, to install explosion-proof safety equipment meeting federal standards.

Day has said he will ask the Justice Department to assign U.S. marshals to protect his force of safety inspectors when they begin posting closing notices at the mines later this month.

"We don't want to close the mines if we don't have to, but the laws say we do," said an MESA spokesman. Another official charged with overseeing compliance with the mine safety act said most of the 500 operators "made no effort at all to comply" with the law.

"They seemed to be under the impression that if they had good safety records they didn't have to meet new standards," added the official, George Hornbeck.

A MESA spokesman, later in the day, said he had no knowledge of any mine operators being exempted from the action because they had the needed equipment on order.

The spokesman said MESA officials were considering granting extensions to operators who could demonstrate an effort to comply, but that no decision would be made for several more days.

With the Nixon administration already predicting a possible 20-million-ton shortfall of coal this year the FEO urged MESA either to defer compliance with the closure provisions or to amend the rules to permit only partial compliance.

Officials estimated that 3,000 to 6,000 miners will lose their jobs as a result of the closings.

United Mine Workers President Arnold Miller, whose union is pushing for strict enforcement of safety regulations, said he supported the [illegible] Few of his members work in the affected mines, most of them located in the Appalachian region.

John L. Kilcullen, a Washington attorney representing the National Independent Coal Operators Association, said the expense involved in installing the new safety equipment makes it impossible for small mine operators to keep working.

Demo Sweep Forecast

NORMAN, Okla. (AP) — House Speaker Carl Albert predicted that Democrats will capture more than 300 seats in the House in this year's elections, forging their largest majority since before World War II.

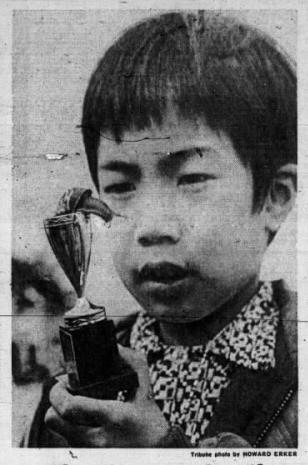
Tunisia Minister, Kissinger to Talk

WASHINGTON (AP) — Secretary of State Henry A. Kissinger plans to meet with Foreign Minister Habib Chatti of Tunisia this morning, embassy officials said.

Chatti is here as what U.S. officials describe as a "get acquainted visit." He became foreign minister Jan. 14.

Kissinger will begin talks in Moscow March 25 on preparations for President Nixon's visit to the Soviet Union later in the year, White House officials announced here yesterday.

The announcement, made jointly here and in the Soviet capital, said Kissinger's discussions also would "lay the groundwork for bilateral relations and international matters of mutual concern."



Tribune photo by HOWARD ERKER

The Fastest Snail

Stanley Fong, 6, admires the fastest snail in Oakland. Stanley's entry won the Lincoln Square Center St. Patrick's Day Snail Race yesterday by covering a measured 9½-inch track in two minutes. Stanley's snail beat a field of 80 competitors to take home the oversized trophy. Another photo on page 15.

Nixon Warning to Squabbling Allies

CHICAGO (AP) — President Nixon escalated the trans-Atlantic war of words yesterday by warning Europe that the United States is ready to "go separately" in trade and defense policy unless the Atlantic alliles reach a prompt agreement on a new cooperative relationship.

"The day of the one-way street is gone," the President declared as he ruled out any early summit session, or one simply to reshape the North Atlantic Treaty Organization on NATO's 25th anniversary next month. That agreement is known to be ready.

"Until Europe is as willing to cooperate on the economic and political front, no meeting of heads of state will occur," Nixon said in answering questions here before the Executives Club.

Nixon also said yesterday that when John W. Dean III told him that hush money was being paid to the original Watergate defendants he considered it an allegation rather than a fact.

The President sought to resolve differences in his past accounts of what occurred during a meeting he had with Dean and H.R. Haldeman on March 21, 1973.

Saying there "may have been a misapprehension" about what he said at a news conference a week ago in Washington, Nixon described what Dean had told him as an allegation.

At his March 6 news conference, Nixon said that Dean told him for the first time on March 21, 1973, "that payments had been made to the defendants for the purpose of keeping them quiet, not simply for their defense."

This statement at his last news conference conflicted with his statement last Aug. 15 about exactly what Dean told him during the March 21, 1973, meeting.

Last Aug. 15, he said: "I was only told that the money had been used for attorneys' fees and family support, not that it had been paid to procure silence. . ."

The President referred to a number of other Watergate allegations including that he had authorized offers of elemency to defendants and had approved the burglary of the office of Daniel Ellsberg's psychiatrist then said, "They are all totally false. And the investigations will prove it."

Nixon also vowed yesterday he would not resign because "I will not be a party to the destruction of the presidency of the United States."

In responding to 14 questions during the hour-long session, the President also:

— Cautioned Arabs not to attach conditions to lifting of the oil embargo. He said this would slow down U.S. peace efforts in the Middle East.

— Declared he would not grant House impeachment investigators a "fishing license" to pawe through confidential White House files; called for the House Judiciary Committee to follow the Constitution in defining an impeachable offense, and again urged prompt resolution of impeachment moves.

— Ruled out his personal testimony in the Watergate coverup trials of former White House aides, and indicated "there may be evidence" he owes more federal income taxes because paperwork on donation of his vice presidential files was not completed in time.

— Repeated that the back of the energy crisis has been broken and said the best way to deal with long-term energy shortages is "not to demagogue" but "for the Congress to get off its something and do something about it right now."

— Said the emigration of Soviet Jews has increased sharply as U.S.-Soviet relations have improved and said it is "much better to have your voice heard inside the Kremlin . . . because those walls are mighty thick."

— Again conceded that inflation remains a troublesome problem, but predicted "it will go down" during the latter part of this year with improved supplies of energy and food.

On the Inside

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Hidden stash of Nixon tapes claimed. Page 3.

Witness says slaying suspect was in mortuary. Page 5.

Emeryville ferry will be profitable, expert says. Page 15.

'Backlash' blamed for Lutheran church split. Page 20.

Scientists claim 'breeder' A-plants safe. Page 30.

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Fire-Bomb Holocaust In Caracas

CARACAS, Venezuela (AP) — A wave of fires and bombings swept Caracas Thursday night and early yesterday, causing millions of dollars in damage.

Venezuela's new government blamed "anarchist groups of adventurers" for the fires, which apparently were a response by terrorists to the inauguration of President Carlos Andres Perez on Tuesday.

Mrs. Pat Nixon was an honored guest at the inauguration and departed Venezuela shortly before the devastation.

Interior Minister Luis Pinerua told newsmen there was no evidence to attribute the acts to leftist organizations.

However, several radio stations and newspapers said they had received calls from persons claiming to be members of Red Flag, a leftist terrorist group. The callers claimed the group had set the fires and was responsible for four pipeline explosions.

Police said total damage could exceed $30 million.

The fires have destroyed a huge warehouse complex and damaged a supermarket and department store as well as oil pipelines.

Explosions and fires also damaged oil and natural gas pipelines used both by the state oil company and three foreign firms.

Pinerua and Caracas Gov. Diego Arria held emergency meetings with military and state security forces, and Pinerua said later that the government would "guarantee the peace."

Several persons have been arrested and are being held in connection with the incidents, Pinerua said.

A government source said about 100 persons had been arrested.

Police estimated damage at $22 million in a Thursday night blaze that destroyed an eight-building warehouse complex used to store such imported goods as newsprint, liquor and cotton, and a fire early yesterday at a supermarket owned by the Rockefeller family.

A small fire also was reported yesterday in a department store in an eastern Caracas suburb and two other stores, including the U.S.-owned Sears department store, reported finding unexploded firebombs.

Perez was sworn in as Venezuela's 39th president Tuesday. He is well known for his tough stand as interior minister during the guerrilla-plagued presidency of Romulo Betancourt from 1958 to 1963.

Perez was largely responsible for hard-line tactics used against leftist guerrillas who, with the backing of Cuba, attempted to plunge the country into chaos following the 1958 ouster of dictator Marcos Perez Jimenez and the election of Betancourt.

Guerrilla groups were active during the terms of Betancourt and his successor, Raul Leoni, but gradually diminished following the 1968 election of Perez' predecessor, Rafael Caldera.

Kidnapers Take Banker's Wife, Ask Ransom

MINNEAPOLIS, Minn. (AP) — The FBI reported last night that the wife of the president of a South St. Paul bank apparently has been kidnaped.

Agents said Eunice H. Kronholm, 48, wife of Genur Kronholm, president of Drovers State Bank, was last seen early Friday morning as she drove away from her home in her car. The Kronholm's live at Hugo, 15 miles north of St. Paul.

The FBI said Kronholm received a telephone call at 3:40 p.m. Friday in which an anonymous caller said, "We have your wife. Deliver all the money you can get to a station."

The FBI said the caller made no specific ransom demands and did not indicate what was meant by "station."

Kronholm said he had not received a second call.

"We are just standing by waiting for instructions," he said.

An agent at the FBI office in Minneapolis said their records showed the Kronholms have six grown children, none at home.

Strike Over, S.F. Picking Up Pieces

San Francisco's cable cars were again climbing half-way to the stars last night after the board of supervisors and city employes' unions voted to ratify a $9.5 million pay increase to end the nine-day strike.

Municipal Railway workers were back on the job by 6 p.m. and full normal schedules were promised for today. As weary bargainers left city hall after the 5-3 vote, janitors began working on the accumulation of trash that had built up during the strike.

Supervisor John Barbagelata, who, with Quentin Kopp and John Molinari had voted against the settlement, predicted a ballot referendum seeking to nullify the pay raise would be put before the voters in the next election.

And Victor Levit, attorney for the Chamber of Commerce, said he was prepared to file suit testing the legality of the increase and would sponsor the form of referendum Barbagelata mentioned.

After the package emerged from day-and-night negotiations, it took the supervisors three hours of bitter debate before voting 5-3 to accept the terms. The dissenters argued that the true cost of the raise will eventually reach some $12 million a year.

The agreement calls for an across-the-board raise of $45 a month as of July 1, the beginning of the new fiscal year, with another $10 a month in January.

Barbagelata said this represents "a total sellout of employes—some will get steaks, with potatoes to the rest." He favored a percentage scale. He and Kopp had boycotted the final negotiations because they were held in secret.

The settlement also calls for a dental plan, worth another half-million dollars a year, if its legality can be established.

Mayor Joseph Alioto and other supervisors said several million dollars—the estimates range from $3.2 million to $5.3 million—in unpaid salaries were saved during the strike.

Nearby, at Nourse Auditorium, the memberships of the combined unions were voting 750-241 to accept.

Teachers' Talks Next For Alioto

San Francisco Mayor Joseph L. Alioto, after successfully mediating the end of the city employes' strike, returns to the negotiation table this morning in an effort to end the city's teacher walkout.

Alioto and the board of education are scheduled to meet at 10 a.m. today in the Del Webb Town House Hotel with representatives of the San Francisco Classroom Teachers' Association, the district's Certificated Employe Council and special support personnel from the National Education Assn. and the California Teachers' Association.

The mayor said he would hold all-night sessions in an effort to settle the dispute this weekend so all the district's 78,000 pupils can return to class.

The issues are salaries and class size, with the American Federation of Teachers Local 61, representing some 2,500 of the district's 4,100 teachers, asking for a 15 per cent pay raise and a limit on class size.

The top offer the school district said it could make was a 6 per cent raise.

Alioto, hoarse and visibly wearied by the municipal strike talks, said the teachers' strike might present greater difficulties in reaching a settlement. But he added:

"If possible to open the schools Monday, I will spend the weekend working on it."

Warriors Win, Regain Lead; Seals Beaten

The Warriors regained the NBA's Pacific Division lead last night by winning probably their most important game of the season 112-107 over Los Angeles in Inglewood. The teams play tonight in the Coliseum Arena.

The Seals weren't so fortunate, losing 5-1 to Pittsburgh at the Arena.

UCLA goes for its eighth straight NCAA Western Regional title against USF today in Tucson, and a shot at an eighth consecutive national championship in next week's finals.

Details in sports